

Six Poems

Woke Through Thunder
King of the Forest
Open the Final Door
Tool of the Trade
Born Into the Line
This Skin

Steve Gutsche

2026

Woke Through Thunder

— Steve Glitsche —

Dirt road living under a borrowed sky
Creek runs high and the coffee's running dry
Pocket full of nothing, head full of plans
Just light playing tricks through these weathered hands

• • •

I've been down but I ain't under
Slept through lightning, woke through thunder
Bent by the weight of a world I didn't make
Laughing at the beauty of a dream that's fake

• • •

The suits and the systems and the locked front doors
Are just furniture arrangements on imaginary floors
We're all just characters who forgot we wrote the play
Arguing about the plot while the author looks away

• • •

What is money but a number we agreed to fear
What is struggle but the universe just shifting gear
The creek don't know my debts, the rain don't know my name
And the mountain smiles at everyone who plays the game

• • •

Rich man, poor man, beggar at the door
We're all just wearing costumes we've forgotten to ignore
The billionaire and the bush camp and the space between
Are pixels in a painting that nobody's really seen

• • •

I've been down but I ain't under
Slept through lightning, woke through thunder

Looked behind the curtain at the wizard running things
Found a kid with a flashlight and a handful of imaginings

• • •

They built the cage so slowly that we thought it was a home
Hung mirrors on the bars so we'd feel less alone
Called the illusion freedom, called the contract choice
Taught us all to sing along and called it our own voice

• • •

Nothing on the news is new, nothing in the store is real
Every want they sold us was a wound they helped us feel
The game was rigged before you learned the name of every piece
But even knowing that somehow the hunger doesn't cease

• • •

That's the genius of the trick, the beauty of the trap
You can see the strings above you and still fall through the gap
Awake inside the dreaming, laughing at the cost
Knowing that you're found my friend the moment that you're lost

• • •

So build your castles carefully or don't build them at all
The joke's the same whether you rise or whether you fall
The construct holds us tenderly like water holds the rain
Until we pour ourselves back into everything again

• • •

And still the morning comes around
Still the fire makes its sound
Still something in the joke says rise
And wink at the light behind your eyes

King of the Forest

— Steve Gutsche —

Didn't know it was a game
Didn't know there were rules
Just woke up one morning
In a world that nobody chose
Came in ancient but an infant
No map and no plan
Just a blank slate and a question
And two empty hands

...

A spark of the divine chose to play
Left his memory at the door
A babe in the woods
Becomes king of the forest
When he remembers what he came here for

...

Rules and I never did get along
Trouble knew my name
Never went looking for the storm
The storm came just the same
Everything's a lesson
Trouble most of all
The harder the classroom
The higher you fall

...

Built the cage and called it living
Called the chain a path
The joke's been there the whole time

Just waiting on the laugh
Funny thing about a rigged game
Once you see it you can't unsee
Funnier still when you realize
You designed the whole damn thing

• • •

Saw through it quiet one morning
Not a crash just a click
Everything I thought was real
Just a magician's trick
One law left when the smoke cleared
Older than the game
Written in the creeks and canyon walls
Before the world had a name

• • •

A spark of the divine chose to play
Left his memory at the door
A babe in the woods
Becomes king of the forest
He remembers what he came here for
He finally remembers
What he came here for

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Open the Final Door

— Steve Gutsche —

Stepping into the game
Deaf dumb and blind
Feeling for the edges
Leave the map behind

• • •

Indoctrination
School of control
Trying to shape you
Mold your very soul
Giving you the answers
Just the wrong ones
But if you know you know

• • •

They say patience is a virtue
But the waiting never ends
I can wait forever
Playing their silly game
Plans are poised and ready
Time is an illusion anyway

• • •

Just a stranger in a strange land
A stranger in a strange land

• • •

Have to really wonder
What it's all for
Stop looking—
The answer isn't out there

It's sitting inside
Waiting for recognition
Knocking at the door

• • •

Looking in the mirror
Seeing the light behind my eyes
Knowing this is just a visit
Past present future
All fading into one

• • •

Looking in the mirror
Seeing the real you
The source of everything is calling

• • •

Open the final door...

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Tool of the Trade

— Steve Gutsche —

Pocket full of nothing, still I know the score
Money's just a hammer, not what hammers are for
You can drive it like a nail or you can let it rust
Either way the sun comes up and turns it back to dust

• • •

Some men clutch it tighter when they feel the cold
That fear becomes the cage that keeps them from the gold
It's a frequency like sunlight, like the rain, like the wind
Close your fist against it and it won't come in

• • •

It's a tool not a treasure, a road not a home
Enough to keep you moving, enough to not be alone
Open hands can catch it, closed ones turn it away
Just a tool of the trade boys, meant to flow not stay

• • •

Paper promises printed by the ton
Backed by nothing but the faith of everyone
They print it thin and call the fiction wealth
While gold and silver keep their counsel in stealth

• • •

Gold remembers every hand that held it there
Silver keeps its counsel, patient, holding fair
Paper burns and fades to empty air
Just a promise long past due and wearing thin

• • •

It's a tool not a treasure, a road not a home
Enough to keep you moving, enough to not be alone

Open hands can catch it, closed ones turn it away
Just a tool of the trade boys, meant to flow not stay

• • •

I know the signal, I know the tune
Still working on my receiver
The miles between them teaching me
Still burning off the distance
Yeah, burning off the distance

• • •

The river doesn't hoard itself, it just keeps moving through
What you put out finds you, that much I know is true
A roof over a stranger, given not from fear but grace
Money finds the open hand and returns in faith

• • •

It's a tool not a treasure, a road not a home
Enough to keep you moving, enough to not be alone
Open hands can catch it, closed ones turn it away
Just a tool of the trade boys, meant to flow not stay

• • •

Just a tool of the trade boys
Meant to flow not stay
Just a tool of the trade
Flowing on its way
Gold remembers
Silver knows
Paper fades
But value flows

Born Into the Line

— Steve Gutsche —

Mama said get in line, boy, soon as you hit the ground
Handed you a number before you made a sound
Waiting for the schoolbell, waiting for the dark to break
Waiting on a love that takes its own sweet time to wake

• • •

Life is just a queue, brother, one foot then the next
Waiting on the doctor, waiting on the check
Waiting for tomorrow like it's gonna set you free
But the line don't care if your soul is wrecked

• • •

Like a racehorse locked up in the barn, muscle coiled and burning hot
Ready to run for open ground, but the latch won't give a shot
Pacing the same four walls, kicking at the same old gate
Strong enough to run forever, just gotta wait, gotta wait

• • •

Life is just a queue, brother, one foot then the next
Waiting on the doctor, waiting on the check
Waiting for tomorrow like it's gonna set you free
But the line don't care if your soul is wrecked

• • •

Maybe they ain't keeping the gate closed to break my will
Trust the hand that holds the latch, even if it ain't a friend
Old horse in the barn don't ask why the seasons turn
Just paws at the straw, and learns to wait, not yearn

• • •

Life is just a queue, brother, one foot then the next
Waiting on the doctor, waiting on the check

Waiting for tomorrow like it's gonna set you free
But the line don't care if your soul is wrecked

• • •

So let the line keep moving slow, let the gate stay shut a while
Some things look like punishment but they're dressed up like a trial
Every wait's a lesson wrapped in a curse
Still standing in the queue — but I know what I knew first

• • •

Life is just a queue, brother, and the queue's just a door
Waiting on the moment that you've been living for
Waiting for tomorrow like it's gonna set you free
But maybe it's the waiting that has been teaching me

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This Skin — *Steve Gutsche* —

I've been broke down on roads with no name,
slept under skies that didn't care,
carried weight that bent me sideways —
but I found my feet, I'm still standing there.

• • •

I've walked through fire that would've stopped most men,
took the hits and took the fall,
but every time the darkness tried to own me
I rose up stronger from it all.

• • •

I've met the man who needed proving,
chased approval like a second sun —
spent so long becoming someone else
I nearly missed the man beneath the skin.

• • •

Hard lessons. Long years.
The world had plenty to say.
I know who I am now —
and I learned it the hard way.

• • •

The noise that used to shake me doesn't reach me,
the voices that once ruled me lost their throne,
I've seen behind the curtain of the chaos —
and found a peace I've never known.

• • •

The mystery that haunted every question,
the why behind the what behind the where —

it didn't need an answer from the outside,
it was waiting in the silence, always there.

• • •

There's a quiet now that nothing can disturb,
settled deep where the storm used to live,
not the quiet of a man who's given up —
the quiet of a man who's learned to give

• • •

himself permission just to be exactly
what the long road shaped him to become,
no apology for how the edges landed —
I know the journey and I know where I'm from.

• • •

Hard lessons. Long years.
The world had plenty to say.
I know who I am now —
and I learned it the hard way.

• • •

This skin has earned its fit.
These hands have earned their rest.
The mystery is solved —
and the answer is yes.

• • •

Hard lessons. Long years.
The world had plenty to say.
I know who I am now —
and I learned it the hard way.